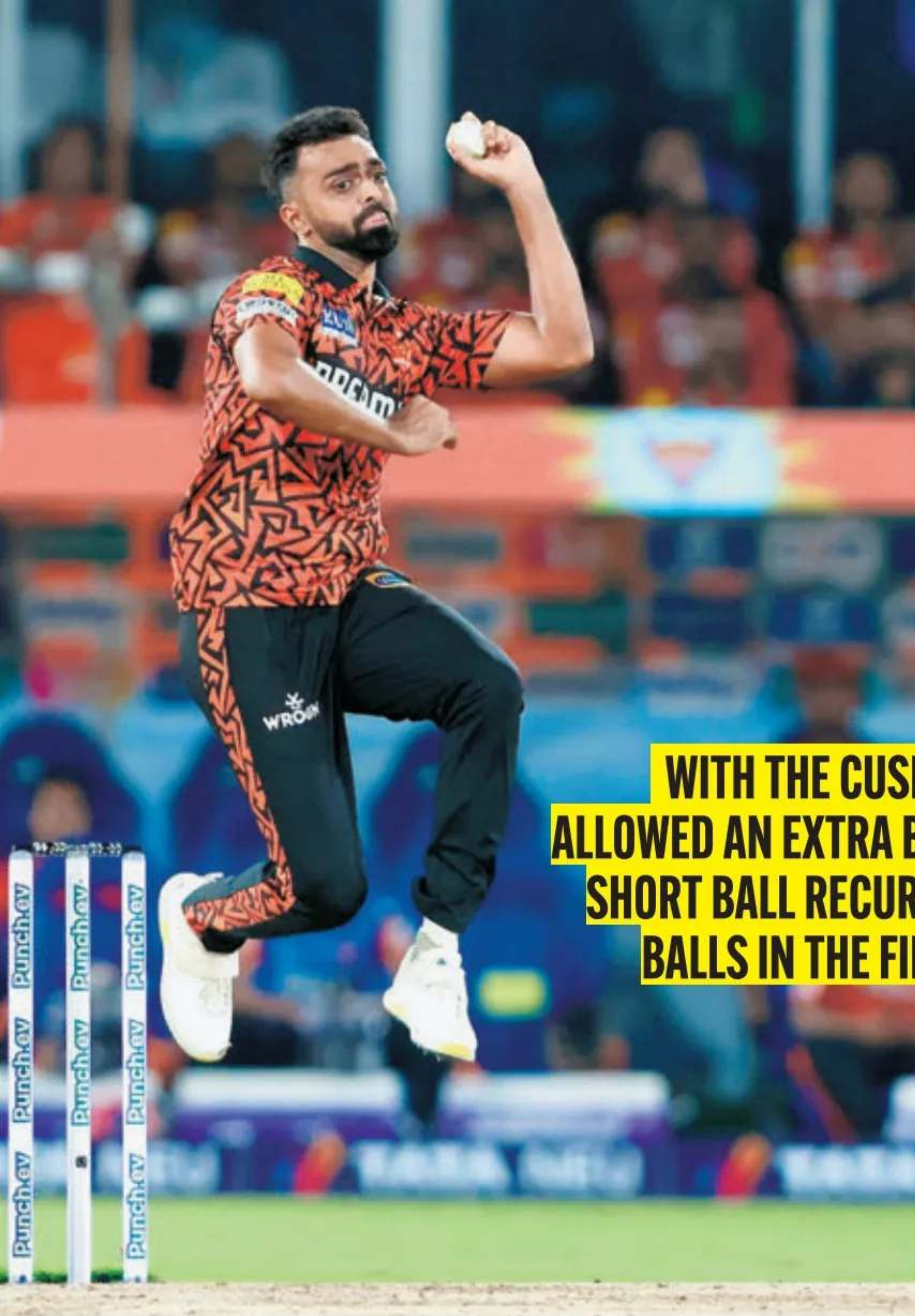




Effective weapon: Sunrisers Hyderabad seamer Jaydev Unadkat's wily use of the slower ball bouncer has left the batters guessing. SPORTZPICS / IPL

Kings, said.

In keeping with what Unadkat says, the provision to allow two bouncers in an over has drastically reduced the predictability of the short ball, an element that is key to making the delivery more potent. The ongoing season of the IPL has witnessed a more equal distribution of the short ball across the first six deliveries of an over.

But even though bowlers are allowed to spring a surprise more often, the short-pitched ball is still an option fraught with danger. After the rank full toss, which yields more than 13 runs every six times it is bowled, the short delivery is the second-most profligate, going at almost 11.5 runs an over.

Despite the apparent expensive character of the short ball, it remains a key cog in the bowler's arsenal due to its proficiency in providing crucial breakthroughs. Among the different lengths employed by fast bowlers, the short ball is the most effective wicket-taking weapon.

In IPL 2023, short balls induced a wicket every 13 balls. The fuller length was the next best delivery for the pacers, scalping one every 16 balls, while the yorker, considered a potent delivery, produced a wicket every 27 balls.

The enforcement of the two-bouncer rule has given the bowlers the license to put this munition to better use.

Rajasthan Royals' bowler Sandeep Sharma is among those exultant over the new rule. "Earlier, the batters were able to predict where the bowler would bowl if he had used his one bouncer already. But with two bouncers, the batters are also in two

WITH THE CUSHION OF BOWLERS BEING ALLOWED AN EXTRA BOUNCER THIS YEAR, THE SHORT BALL RECURRED ALMOST EVERY FIVE BALLS IN THE FIRST 13 MATCHES OF THIS EDITION OF THE IPL

minds that there is still one bouncer left for the bowler to use," the pacer said.

"Talking about the [batter's] body weight, even if you have not executed it [the second short ball] and the body weight has not yet been transferred, the bowler can still be on the safer side. Hence, this rule is beneficial," the 30-year-old said.

The data also suggests that teams have exploited the rule well in the second innings. Teams have used the short ball 20 per cent more in the second innings than in the first, employing it astutely while defending targets — eight out of 13 matches have been won by the team batting first.

A comparison of data between the current and previous IPL seasons provides further evidence but with a small caveat. The short ball ploy proves to be effective only through